

THE STUFF OF SOIL

Soil is like a cake mix – made up of ingredients. The four ingredients in soil are minerals, water, air, and organic matter (living or once-living things). Different combinations of each make up different types of soil.

Water

Water soaks into the soil after rain. Minerals and nutrients dissolve into the water to form a soil solution. Most water drains through burrows and cracks, but some will remain in small spaces between soil particles, called pores.

Soil can fill up with water so it pools on the surface.

20-30%

Organic matter

Living roots and millions of soil organisms, from microscopic fungi to creepy crawlies, are all organic matter. This also includes dead things, such as leaves that are decaying (breaking down).

Leaves take 6 to 12 months to decompose.

Beetles lay eggs in soil, which hatch into larvae.

Larvae

Decayed leaves

5%

Broccoli grows well in clay soils, which store lots of water and nutrients.